

CYBERSECURITY TRAINING MODULE

Phishing Awareness Training

Recognize the bait. Question the request. Protect the data.

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Cybersecurity Internship Project



AGENDA

What We'll Cover

1

What Is Phishing?

Definition, scale, and why it works

2

Types of Phishing Attacks

Email, spear phishing, whaling & more

3

Anatomy of a Phishing Email

Reading the red flags line by line

4

Spotting Fake Websites

URLs, certificates, and design tells

5

Social Engineering Tactics

The psychology attackers exploit

6

Real-World Case Studies

Lessons from major breaches

7

Best Practices & Prevention

Habits that stop most attacks

8

Incident Response

What to do if you get phished

01 • FOUNDATIONS

What Is Phishing?

Phishing is a social engineering attack where a criminal impersonates a trusted person, brand, or system to trick a victim into **handing over credentials, money, or sensitive data** — usually through a fake email, message, or website.

- It relies on manipulating human trust, not breaking encryption or code.
- It is the most common way attackers gain initial access to a network.
- Anyone with an inbox, phone, or social media account is a target.

SOURCE: VERIZON 2024 DBIR

68%

of data breaches involve a human element — error, stolen credentials, or falling for social engineering.

21 sec

median time for a user to click a link

28 sec

more to then enter sensitive data

Types of Phishing Attacks



Email Phishing

Mass, generic emails impersonating a bank, brand, or service to harvest credentials.



Spear Phishing

Personalized attacks using researched details about one specific target.



Whaling

Spear phishing aimed at executives — often fake wire-transfer or legal requests.



Smishing

Phishing delivered via SMS text, often with a malicious short link.



Vishing

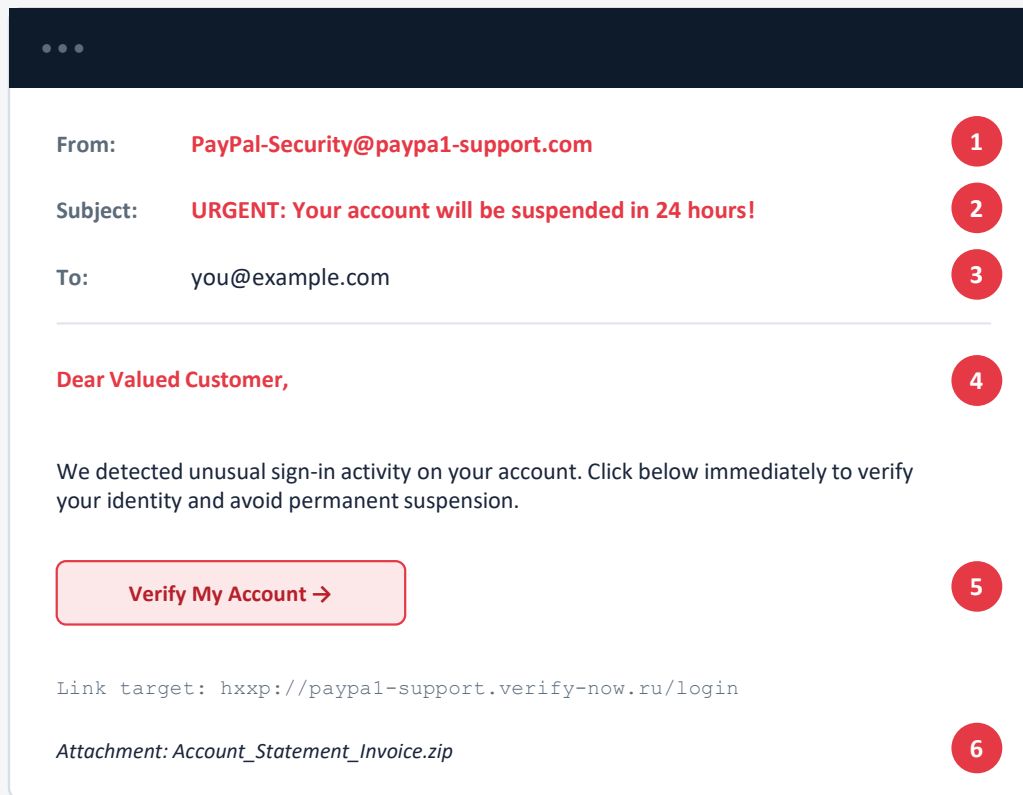
Voice-call phishing — attacker poses as IT support, a bank, or law enforcement.



Clone Phishing

A real, previously delivered email is copied and resent with a malicious link.

Anatomy of a Phishing Email



RED FLAGS TO CHECK

- 1 Spoofed sender domain — "paypa1" uses a digit 1, not the letter I
- 2 Manufactured urgency to short-circuit careful thinking
- 3 Generic greeting instead of your real name
- 4 Pressure to act "immediately" to avoid a consequence
- 5 Link text hides a mismatched, suspicious destination URL
- 6 Unexpected attachment used to deliver malware

Spotting Fake Websites

URL

Warning Signs in the URL

- ☐ Misspelled or altered domain (paypa1.com, arnazon.com)
- ☐ Extra words, numbers, or hyphens before the real brand name
- ☐ Unusual top-level domain for the brand (.ru, .xyz, .top)
- ☐ A raw IP address instead of a real domain name
- ☐ A long, confusing subdomain trying to hide the true host

WEB

Warning Signs on the Page

- ☐ No padlock icon, or the connection is not "https://"
- ☐ Low-quality logos, layout, or spelling and grammar errors
- ☐ Pop-ups demanding an urgent login or payment
- ☐ Requests for more data than the task requires
- ☐ No verifiable contact info, address, or "About" page

Social Engineering Tactics

Phishing rarely breaks technology — it exploits predictable human reactions.

1

Urgency & Fear

"Act now or lose access" pushes victims to skip verification.

2

Authority

Impersonating a boss, bank, or government agency to demand compliance.

3

Curiosity

A tempting subject line or attachment baits a careless click.

4

Trust & Familiarity

Spoofing a known contact or brand to lower suspicion.

5

Scarcity

"Limited time offer" or "one login attempt left" forces quick decisions.

6

Reciprocity

A small favor or gift creates pressure to return it with information.

Real-World Phishing Incidents

2013–2015

Google & Facebook

\$100M+ Business Email Compromise

An attacker impersonated a hardware vendor both companies worked with, forging invoices and emails that convinced finance teams to wire over \$100 million across two years.

2020

Twitter

High-Profile Account Takeover

Attackers used phone-based spear phishing (vishing) to trick employees into handing over credentials for internal admin tools, then hijacked dozens of verified accounts for a crypto scam.

2013

Target

40M+ Payment Cards Exposed

A phishing email sent to a third-party HVAC vendor delivered malware that stole network credentials, which attackers then used to breach Target's payment systems.

Best Practices to Avoid Falling Victim



Before You Click

- ✓ Verify the sender's real email address, not just the display name
- ✓ Hover over links to preview the actual destination URL
- ✓ Pause on any message using urgency, fear, or pressure tactics
- ✓ Never trust caller ID alone — phone numbers can be spoofed
- ✓ When in doubt, contact the sender through a separate, known channel

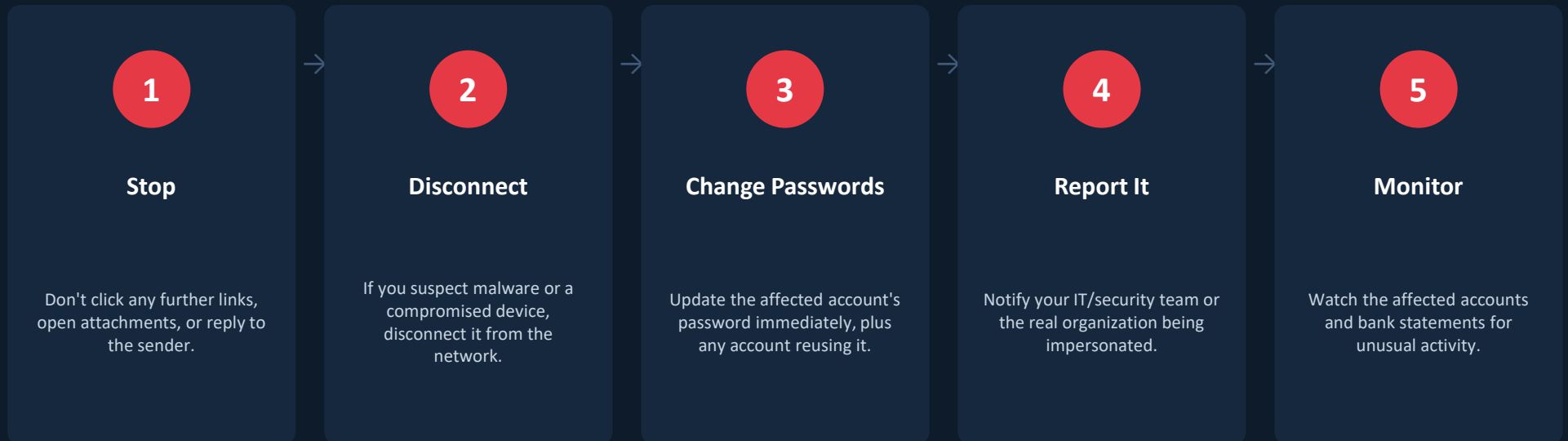


Ongoing Protection

- ✓ Turn on multi-factor authentication (MFA) everywhere it's offered
- ✓ Use a password manager and unique passwords per account
- ✓ Keep your OS, browser, and apps updated with security patches
- ✓ Enable spam and anti-phishing filtering on email and browsers
- ✓ Report suspicious messages to IT/security instead of just deleting

What To Do If You Get Phished

Speed matters. Move through these steps calmly and in order.



Test Your Knowledge

This module pairs with a short interactive quiz to reinforce what you just learned.

1

Spot the Red Flags

Identify suspicious elements in a sample phishing email.

2

Real or Fake Website?

Decide whether a shown URL is legitimate or spoofed.

3

Name the Tactic

Match a scenario to the social engineering tactic used.

4

What Would You Do?

Choose the correct first response to a phishing attempt.

SUMMARY

Key Takeaways

1

Pause before you click

Urgency is a manufactured pressure tactic — slow down and verify.

2

Check the source

Verify sender addresses, domains, and phone numbers independently.

3

Layer your defenses

MFA, password managers, and updated software stop most attacks even after a click.

4

Report, don't ignore

Reporting a phishing attempt protects the rest of your organization too.

Stay Alert. Stay Secure.

Thank you for completing the Phishing Awareness Training module.

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